

4.1.2 Aspects of comedy

At the centre of all set texts are stories which primarily amuse, where the discomfort of characters generally excites laughter rather than concern and where no great disaster occurs. All texts contain a love interest for the protagonist and marriage is a focal point. In all cases society itself (as represented in the texts), and the behaviour of men and women in it, are ridiculed. The texts must be explored in terms of the aspects that are apparent in them. The absence of an aspect might also be of note. There can be no exhaustive list of the 'aspects' of comedy but areas that can usefully be explored include:

- the type of the comedy text itself, whether it is classic romantic drama, a satire, a comedy of manners
- the settings for the comedy, both places and times
- the journey towards knowledge and happiness for the protagonists, often in relation to their love interest, their mistakes and misunderstandings along their journey, moments of unhappiness and ultimate sense of joy
- the role of the comic villain, or rival, who directly affects the fortune of the hero or heroine, who causes some disruption to the cheerful mood but whose power is finally curtailed
- the sense that all will end well and that fortune smiles
- how the behaviour of the hero or heroine affects primarily themselves and perhaps one or two others rather than countries and states, as in tragedy
- the significance of human folly, trickery and gullibility
- the inclusion of clowns, exaggeration, stereotypes, pompous attitudes and posturing
- the use of disguise, escapes and discovery, elements of the supernatural
- the structural patterning of the text as it moves from disorder to order, incorporating rule and misrule, how competition between characters is set up and resolved, how opposites are contrasted and reconciled, leading to comic resolutions
- the use of complex plotting and sub-plots
- the way that language is used to heighten the comedy, particularly wit and linguistic play
- the way that comedy draws attention to itself
- ultimately how the comedy affects the audience, inviting laughter at the ridiculous behaviour of human beings and a sense of joy that positive resolutions are possible.

Students study **one** of the following Shakespeare plays:

Author	Text
William Shakespeare	<i>The Taming of the Shrew</i>
	<i>Twelfth Night</i>

Students study **two** texts from the following list: **one** pre-1900 drama text and **one** further text.

Author	Text	Time period
Jane Austen	<i>Emma</i>	Pre-1900

Author	Text	Time period
Geoffrey Chaucer	'The Nun's Priest's Tale' including Prologue and Epilogue	Pre-1900
Oliver Goldsmith	<i>She Stoops to Conquer</i> (drama)	Pre-1900
Andrea Levy	<i>Small Island</i>	
Oscar Wilde	<i>The Importance of Being Earnest</i> (drama)	Pre-1900
AQA English Literature B Poetry anthology (comedy)	'The Flea', 'Tam o' Shanter', 'A Satirical Elegy on the Death of a Late Famous General', 'Sunny Prestatyn', 'Mrs Sisyphus', 'Not My Best Side', 'My Rival's House'	

As with all the requirements around genre/dates in this specification, a text can fulfil more than one category. So, for example, *She Stoops to Conquer* covers the requirement for a drama text and a text written pre-1900.

We do not expect to change texts within the first five years of the specification. However, texts will be reviewed each year starting in September 2017 and we will give at least nine months' notice of any changes prior to first teaching of a two year course. The criteria for changing texts will be where a text becomes unavailable or where we can no longer use it in a question paper. Notice of any change will be communicated via our exam bulletins and aqa.org.uk/english